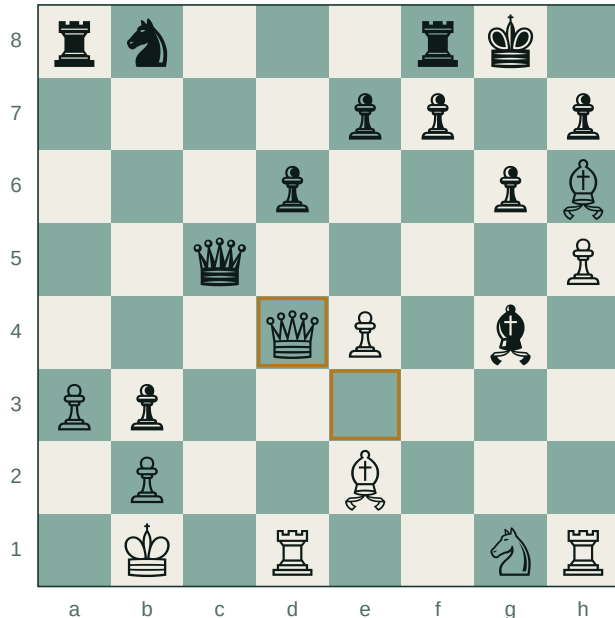


Mate in three: Black, move 20

Mate in three

Black to move



Previous move: 20.Qxd4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20...Qc2+ 21. Ka1 Rxa3+ 22. bxa3 Qa2#

20...Qc2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From c2 it attacks king on b1, rook on d1 and bishop on e2. Recorded reply: **21.Ka1**.

21...Rxa3+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on a3. Recorded reply: **22.bxa3**.

22...Qa2# Mate: queen on a2 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on a1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on a2. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on b1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on h6 and rook on h1. Check for tactical protection.